# Palestinian Poetry Collection

By Naomi Shihab Nye and Taha Muhammad Ali

## INTRODUCTION

*Naomi Shihab Nye was born in St. Louis to an American mother and a Palestinian father, Aziz Shihab, a refugee from the war of 1948. Being American and Palestinian puts her at the confluence of two warring rivers, an uncomfortable position that grew only more painful during Israel's assault on Gaza and Lebanon. All Things Not Considered by Naomi Shihab Nye.*

## All Things Not Considered

You cannot stitch the breath
back into this boy.

A brother and sister were playing with toys
when their room exploded.

*In what language*
*is this holy?*

The Jewish boys killed in the cave
were skipping school, having an adventure.

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Asel Asleh, Palestinian, age 17, believed in the field
beyond right and wrong where people came together

to talk. He kneeled to help someone else
stand up before he was shot.

*If this is holy,*
*could we have some new religions please?*

Mohammed al-Durra huddled against his father
in the street, terrified. The whole world saw him die.

An Arab father on crutches burying his 4 month girl weeps,
"I spit in the face of this ugly world."

*

Most of us would take our children over land.
We would walk in the fields forever homeless
with our children,
huddle under cliffs, eat crumbs and berries,
to keep our children.
This is what we say from a distance
because we can say whatever we want.

*

No one was right.
Everyone was wrong.
*What if they'd get together*

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*and say that?*
*At a certain point*
*the flawed narrator wins.*

People made mistakes for decades.
Everyone hurt in similar ways
at different times.
Some picked up guns because guns were given.
If they were holy it was okay to use guns.
Some picked up stones because they had them.
They had millions of them.
They might have picked up turnip roots
or olive pits.
Picking up things to throw and shoot:
at the same time people were studying history,
going to school.

*

The curl of a baby's graceful ear.

The calm of a bucket
waiting for water.

Orchards of the old Arab men
who knew each tree.

Jewish and Arab women
standing silently together.

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Generations of black.

*Are people the only holy land?*

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Naomi Shihab Nye***
***Book: 19 Varieties of Gazelle***
***ISBN: 978-0060097653***
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## TRANSITION

*Where is common sense? Is intensified, extended violence going to help things in the long run? Naomi Shihab Nye denounces the devastating loss of civilian life and infrastructure in Lebanon, and she is grieved by U.S. support for Israel's actions. "It is unfathomable," she says, "that we have people without empathy in positions of power affecting so many innocents." She also has a hard time fathoming the silence in the United States that greeted Israel's war on Lebanon. "It shocks me how many people seem to be able to avoid mentioning 'what goes on' even as it is happening," she says. Jerusalem by Naomi Shihab Nye.*

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## Jerusalem

I'm not interested in
Who suffered the most.
I'm interested in
People getting over it.

Once when my father was a boy
A stone hit him on the head.
Hair would never grow there.
Our fingers found the tender spot
and its riddle: the boy who has fallen
stands up. A bucket of pears
in his mother's doorway welcomes him home.
The pears are not crying.
Later his friend who threw the stone
says he was aiming at a bird.
And my father starts growing wings.

Each carries a tender spot:
something our lives forgot to give us.
A man builds a house and says,
"I am native now."
A woman speaks to a tree in place
of her son. And olives come.
A child's poem says,
"I don't like wars,
they end up with monuments."
He's painting a bird with wings
wide enough to cover two roofs at once.

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Why are we so monumentally slow?
Soldiers stalk a pharmacy:
big guns, little pills.
If you tilt your head just slightly
it's ridiculous.

There's a place in my brain
Where hate won't grow.
I touch its riddle: wind, and seeds.
Something pokes us as we sleep.

It's late but everything comes next.

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## TRANSITION

*A Palestinian word that best reflects the belief system of its people is not easily translated into English: "Samid" which means one who holds on tenaciously to his land and its culture and perseveres in adverse times. Poet Taha Muhammad embodies this concept in his poem "Thrombosis in the Veins of Petroleum." Born in 1931 in Galilee village of Saffuriya, he fled to Lebanon, together with most of the inhabitants of his village, during the Arab-Israeli war of 1948. A year later he slipped back across the border with his family and settled in Nazareth, where he has lived ever since.*

## THROMBOSIS IN THE VEINS OF PETROLEUM

When I was a child
I fell into the abyss
but didn't die;
I drowned in the pond
when I was young,
but did not die;
and now, God help us—
one of my habits is running
into battalions of land mines
along the border,
as my songs
and the days of my youth
are dispersed:
here a flower,

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there a scream;
and yet,
I do not die!
*
They butchered me
on the doorstep
like a lamb for the feast—
thrombosis
in the veins of petroleum;
In God's name
they slit my throat
from ear to ear
a thousand times,
and each time
my dripping blood would swing
back and forth
like the feet of a man
hanged from a gallows,
and come to rest,
a large, crimson mallow
blossom—
a beacon
to guide ships
and mark
the site of palaces
and embassies.
*
And tomorrow,
God help us—
the phone won't ring
in a brothel or castle,

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and not in a single Gulf Emirate,
except to offer a new prescription
for my extermination.
But …
just as the mallow tells us,
and as the borders know,
I won't die! I will not die!!
I'll linger on—a piece of shrapnel
the size of a penknife
lodged in the neck;
I'll remain—
a blood stain
the size of a cloud
on the shirt of this world!

## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Taha Muhammad Ali***
***Book: Never Mind: Twenty Poems and a Story translated by Peter Cole, Yahya Hijazi, and Gabriel Levin***
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